Claire

By John Kuntz

Lights up on Claire, an attractive, rather regal actress. Her age is impossible to determine, but she's been around for a while. Music is blaring and Claire appears to be humming loudly and conducting the music, sans baton. She begins to talk to someone who has just entered the room but does not stop her "conducting" (Song is Bizet - L'Arlesienne Suite No. 2: Farandole)*

CLAIRE: **(Pg 113+)** Please don't turn the music off, it's almost done. No, I'm afraid I can't stop now. I can't stop once it's started, I have to wait until it's finished. Just a few more seconds. I'm almost done. *(She continues. The music ends. Clair takes a moment to catch her breath. She seems almost transported and needs to remember where she is. She addresses the audience)* Well. Quite a show, huh? No applause? *(pause)* No, I don't want you to applaud. It was a joke *(pause)* You're the first person ever to see me do that. And it was absolutely free. Most theatre tickets cost at least 60 dollars these days. But this is actually costing me money, isn't it? So, what's your name? Marcia? Well, that's a nice, sensible name. Marcia *(She tries saying it in different moods and tones)* Marcia . . . Marcia . . . Marcia . . . Marcia . . . Sorry, just trying it on for size. So, Marcia, nice to meet you. I'm Claire.

INTRODUCTION

Claire Wilson had reached the pinnacle of success: a lead role in a Broadway production. The roar of the crowd, the applause, the standing ovations. But there's a darker side to the profession. Acting, while it may be your passion, is an intense career path, with rejections, unpredictable work schedules, strained relationships, and a constant fear that your time in the spotlight is over. How do you cope with the loss of the very profession that has defined your life?

Claire by John Kuntz

CLAIRE: Theatre is a dying art form, did you know that? At least that's what my agent says. *(pause)* My first therapist actually said that I was pursuing a career in theatre for all

EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the wrong reasons. He said I wanted to be on stage because I didn't receive enough attention as a child and this was how I was trying to fulfill this emotional need in my adult life. He said I was completely out of touch with some of the more important emotions like anger and fear and that I was using the characters I play on stage to feel them for me. Because it was safer that way. But I ignored him and kept going and now here I am. A retreat. That's what my agent likes to call it. A "retreat." *(AS HER AGENT)* Oh, Claire is resting. It was a grueling run in New York and she's having a nice little vacation. *(to audience)* Marty has always been marvelous at putting a fresh, positive spin on things. *(pause)*

You know what I love about this place? I love that you actually have a theater here. Right on the grounds of the hospital. Psychodrama. Theatre as therapy. All the kooks putting on a play so they can act out what's wrong with their lives and reach some kind of understanding about themselves. I find it extremely ironic, don't you? I mean acting is what got me into this snake pit in the first place and now it's supposed to get me out? I find that hilarious *(pause)* I could be acting right now for all you know. I mean, who's to say that I haven't planned out everything and make it seem like it's all just floating to the top of my head? Pause. Pause. Pause. Was that spontaneous? OR was it rehearsed? Studied and blocked. Act 5 Scene 2. *(pause)* You get to a point, I mean I do, I get to a point where . . . you don't know what's real anymore. What's honest. You start to become obsessed with it. *(She turns on the music again and begins to wave her arms in the air, as if conducting the music)*

Do you know why I do this? I was auditioning for a very important role. It was the role that would bring me to the next level of my career. I was 23. A leading role -- I wanted that part so badly. And when they called me to say that it was mine, that they wanted me . . . I heard this song playing. I think I'll remember that moment, that feeling of triumph and satisfaction for the rest of my life. This is my lucky song . . . I would play it every time I had an important audition. Right before I left the house. To inspire me . . . And when I came back from the audition, I played it again. For good

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

luck. It was kind of a ritual. That was how it started . . . *(She abruptly shuts off the music)* You have to understand that I'm working in a profession where luck plays a major part, Marcia. And finding some way to control your fortune is a very, very seductive idea. You're going to need luck to get the audition, and the callback, and then the part. And once you have that part, you're going to need luck to keep it. You need to pray every night that you'll remember your lines, remember your blocking, that the lead won't upstage you, that your understudy won't plot your violent murder, that the audience won't laugh during your death scene, or worse walk out, that the reviews are kind, that your voice won't give out, that the play won't close after two weeks, and when it does, you're going to need luck to start the whole thing all over again. *(pause)*

You know, I don't really belong here. I'm fine. In fact, I can't really stay . . . I need to be back in town soon. I'm playing Truly Scrumptious in "Chitty Chitty Bang Bang." It's the stage version of the movie. I know it sounds hideous and it is, but Marty says it's a sure-fire hit, and I'm going to need a hit after all this. Do you know that when I tell some people that I'm an actress they immediately ask what movies I've done. And when I tell them I'm a stage actress they sort of smile, as if to say: "Oh, what a quaint hobby." I would like to make one thing very clear: great acting takes place in the theatre and only the theatre. Because it's alive. It's living. It's happening right in front of you. If something happens or goes wrong during the show then it becomes a part of the show, no two of which are ever the same. You can't stop and start over again. That moment is gone. BANG! Here comes another one! It's happening right in front of you! BANG! And other one! BANG! And another! BANG! BANG! BANG! That is theatre! It's living! It's breathing! It's the Super bowl! It's the Sermon on the Mount! It's Jazz! It's bongo beats and café au lait in a smoky room filled with shadowy smiling strangers! It's the birth of your child! It's yin! It's yang! It's playing poker with God! *(pause)* And so much more. I don't want to insult the experience by

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

trying to describe it but there you go. It's an addicting thing. You can't get enough of it. *(pause)*

So, listen, I suppose you want to hear the whole sordid tale of why I'm here so I might as well tell you so I can get the hell out. The whole thing was an accident. I didn't have a nervous breakdown, I'm fine. The show I had just worked on for God knows how long . . . It was bad luck from the beginning: the wrong director, the wrong theatre, the wrong cast . . . The closer we got to opening night the more I played my lucky song. In the morning before I went to rehearsal . . . at night when I got back, over and over. And soon that wasn't enough. I started to play it in my dressing room during breaks, softly so no one would hear, the door closed. On opening night, half the audience left before Act II and I suddenly realized that just playing the song wasn't enough. I needed to do something to the music. Control it. *(She begins to wave her arms in the air)* I started to conduct, waving my hands, easing the music out. Everything would fall into place if I just did it right.

The reviews came out, the worst I've ever seen for any play in my career . . . "Claire Wilson is a vapid marionette on stage" – New York Times . . . "Claire Wilson is in the twilight of her career . . . not one honest moment . . . – The Village Voice . . . "Claire Wilson is the worst dressed actress on Broadway" – People Magazine . . . "Clair Wilson has a big butt" – The National Inquirer . . .

The male lead was fired after 5 performances . . . The stage manager quit . . . During the curtain call of a matinee performance the audience actually booed. I've never been booed at in my life . . . I started listening to [my song] in the wings right before I went on stage, waving my arms and whirling about, the rest of the cast thought I was crazy, I thought I was crazy and I took small comfort in the notion that I couldn't be crazy if I knew what I was doing was crazy because a crazy person wouldn't know that.

And then Marty called me one afternoon. The show was closing. Last nights' performance for 20 people would be the last. I hung up the phone and just laid there

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

on my bed. I couldn't move. I must have fallen asleep because when I opened my eyes everything was dark. I turned on a light and went over to the mirror. I know how this sounds but I just wanted to look to make sure it was still there . . . The mirror in my bedroom was this large oval full-length one on a stand. The mirror was on hinges to you could spin it around. And I started to spin the mirror like a wheel, faster and faster, until it didn't look like a mirror anymore, just this round motion and flashes of light, and I could see my reflection in between the flashes, and then, and I don't know why I did this but. . . I walked into it. As if it were a door, or space . . . I walked into it . . . and the mirror came crashing down and hit me and shattered. (pause)

I saw, felt, fragments of the mirror flying around me . . . and each chard held a reflection of me . . . but it wasn't me . . . it was every character I had ever lived, every person I had ever turned myself into in the last 20 years . . . They flew all around me and then disappeared . . . *(pause)* I don't remember anything else . . . I woke up in the hospital, and Marty said I had tried to kill myself which is ridiculous. I've never had a suicidal thought in my life . . . It was an accident . . . *(She looks at her wrists)*

So that's it. Are we done? Well, when is our next session? Tomorrow at 3. Well, I'll be here. I'm not going anywhere, evidently. *(Marcia leaves; Clair puts a new cassette in the stereo and speaks to herself)* Marty sent me all the music for ***Chitty Chitty Bang Bang*** so I can work on my songs while I'm here. I don't normally do musicals but. *("Doll on a Music Box" from **Chitty Chitty Bang Bang** plays. Claire sings sadly and begins to conduct . . .)*

What do you see
You people gazing at me
You see a doll on a music box
That's wound by a key
You cannot see
How much I long to be free
Turning around on this music box
That's wound by a key

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John Kuntz
Book: Boston Theater Marathon of Ten-Minute Plays, Volume 2, pg 113
ISBN: 978-0874401547
Publisher: Baker's Plays
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier
CA State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

Bizet - L'Arlesienne Suite No. 2: Farandole
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2y09pD1r-Qs

Video of "Doll on a Music Box" from Chitty Chitty Bang Bang
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BbX3ZSr43KA
Lyrics
https://www.stlyrics.com/lyrics/chittychittybangbang/dollonamusicboxtrulyscrumptious.htm

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY